

Chapter 35 Part 5

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Xu Qingzhu deflated in the elevator.

The moment the door closed, she leaned against the corner and took several deep breaths.

To be honest, her mind was actually completely blank.

She hadn't known that her father had always held such thoughts, hoping she would marry Liang Shi and become a full-time housewife.

Of course, there were still quite a few Omegas in this society who relied on Alphas for support, but most worked together as a couple.

In socialite circles, most were Omega wives who didn't go to work.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't want to become that kind of person.

After arguing with Xu Guangyao, her mood was very low, but after returning to the office, she had to force herself to cheer up and work.

Until Lin Luoxi came to find her.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "What's wrong?"

"Are you okay?" Lin Luoxi handed her a cup of brown sugar water¹. "You look very weak."

"I'm fine." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly, afraid they would worry. "Nothing serious. Have you talked with the marketing department?"

"There's a small problem." Lin Luoxi hesitated but still said: "Now I hear that the higher-ups want to use Zhou Yi'an's design drafts as the flagship items. All our previous plans have become alternatives, including Sally's carefully designed 'Starry Night.'"

"It won't happen." Xu Qingzhu was already mentally prepared for this matter and temporarily reassured Lin Luoxi. "Just continue doing your work well. I guarantee that for this new product launch, your autumn series will definitely be the flagship items. And Sally too - tell her to relax. I won't let her return from America for nothing. If I brought you here just to make you suffer grievances, then what kind of person would I be?"

Lin Luoxi was just worried about her: "Actually, I came just to tell you that Sally and I are here to help, so whether our works are used as flagship items or not doesn't matter. The main thing is Zhou Yi'an's design drafts - although they look pretty good, the style is too dark and doesn't match Minghui's usual concept."

"I understand." Xu Qingzhu smiled strongly. "Thank you, Luoxi."

"No problem." Lin Luoxi said. "Rest up. I just came to tell you."

After Lin Luoxi left, Xu Qingzhu stood at the door and called Zhou Yi'an, asking her to come in for a meeting and to bring her design drafts.

As Lin Luoxi had said, Zhou Yi'an's design talent was indeed high, worthy of her prestigious university graduate status, but the style didn't match Minghui. It absolutely couldn't be used as the flagship item for the new product launch, and couldn't even be brought onto the new product launch stage.

She directly rejected all of Zhou Yi'an's drafts.

Zhou Yi'an asked her: "You have a problem with me, don't you?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "No. Quite the opposite - since you've joined Minghui, I hope to discover the value in you, but this set really can't be used."

Zhou Yi'an scoffed: "Do you understand design? An MBA graduate - why are you interfering in the design field?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't take her contemptuous attitude to heart, but smiled: "My family has been in this business for generations, so do you think I understand? All the accessories I've worn since childhood have been Minghui's. In this area, you really don't have the right to question me."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"If you don't want to use it, then forget it." Zhou Yi'an picked up her design drafts and was about to leave. "I didn't beg you to use them anyway."

"But I think your design talent is pretty good." Xu Qingzhu said. "So you could consider designing a set that fits our concept."

"When a work is given a specific concept, it loses its soul." Zhou Yi'an said. "I don't want themed design."

Xu Qingzhu: "So you can't do it?"

Zhou Yi'an: "...Are you provoking me?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Not at all. I'm just stating facts. I thought RT's annual emerging designer had such great abilities, but it turns out you can only do your own things. Then what's the point of you joining the company?"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She said impatiently: "Mind your own business? I'll join wherever I want."

"Indeed, it's not my business to manage. After all, Miss Zhou has special privileges - she can join wherever she wants." Xu Qingzhu still maintained that bland tone.

Zhou Yi'an: "...Xu Qingzhu, stop being so passive-aggressive. I got in through my abilities. What special privileges did I use?"

"Well, I wouldn't know." Xu Qingzhu said. "As the design department's deputy manager, I haven't seen your abilities. Designers who can't create works even when given a theme - we generally call them third-rate designers."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Fuck." Zhou Yi'an cursed under her breath. "You're the third-rate one. When I was winning awards in international design competitions, you probably didn't even know where you were playing in the mud."

"Then let me see your abilities." Xu Qingzhu said. "Preferably use your work to slap my face hard and make me regret saying these words today."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She was silent for a few seconds, then said through gritted teeth: "What theme?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled and casually threw out two words: "Autumn."

Zhou Yi'an said viciously: "Fine! You just wait!"

Then she slammed Xu Qingzhu's office door without mercy.

Xu Qingzhu leaned back in her chair and exhaled. Sally and Cherry, who had been standing at the door listening to the drama, and Cherry who had returned to hear the complete scene, walked in, both shocked.

After a long while, Cherry said with inner excitement but maintaining composure: "Squeezing every bit of value out of your romantic rival - amazing."

"Blanche, I misunderstood you." Sally sighed. "You're the real master of passive aggression²."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

For a moment, she couldn't tell whether these two were praising or criticizing her.

But Minghui's current situation had indeed pushed her to desperation, so she couldn't even spare Zhou Yi'an.

She just smiled: "Sometimes, garbage is just resources placed in the wrong location."

After hearing this, Sally and Cherry gave her thumbs up: "Worthy of you indeed."

Meanwhile, Zhou Yi'an, who had left the office and returned to her workstation, held the stack of design drafts in her hands, feeling that something was off but unable to say exactly what.

A colleague gossiped and asked her: "What did the young miss want with you?"

Zhou Yi'an expressionlessly threw the stack of design drafts into the trash can: "Changing drafts."

"You got your drafts rejected?" the colleague asked. "Do you still have design drafts to compete for the new product launch?"

"Redraw." Zhou Yi'an said.

Colleague: "..."

The colleague showed a sympathetic expression.

A few seconds later, Zhou Yi'an suddenly threw down the pen she had just used to draw a few lines and cursed under her breath: "Damn."

Had she been played by Xu Qingzhu?

How interesting indeed.

Footnotes:

1. **Brown sugar water (紅糖水):** A traditional Chinese remedy believed to help with fatigue, menstrual discomfort, and general weakness, especially for women.
2. **Master of passive aggression (陰陽家):** Sally uses this term playfully. In Chinese culture, "陰陽" (yin-yang) can refer to being indirect or using subtle sarcasm, which Sally interprets as Xu Qingzhu's skillful use of psychological tactics.